# Full Recommendations Report

## Girls Flag Football — Program, Partnership & Growth Strategy

**Date:** 2026-02-19 | **Prepared by:** TPM Agent

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## Overview

Beyond the core Nike partnership and website, this report covers the full set of program, organizational, and growth recommendations for a girls flag football organization going from zero to one. These are prioritized by impact and sequenced within the overall roadmap.

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## 1. Organization Structure

### Recommendation: File as 501(c)(3) Nonprofit

**Why:** A 501(c)(3) nonprofit (not an LLC) is the correct structure for this mission.

Benefits:

- Parent donations are tax-deductible (drives individual giving)
- Eligible for Nike Community Impact Fund grants
- Eligible for NFL Foundation youth sports grants
- Eligible for Women's Sports Foundation and Title IX-aligned grants
- School districts prefer nonprofit partners (simpler MOU process)
- Corporate sponsors get charitable donation classification (better for their tax treatment)
- More credible story for mission-driven brand partners like Nike

**Action:** Engage a nonprofit/sports law attorney. File IRS Form 1023 (or 1023-EZ for organizations expecting under $50K/year initially). AZ state registration required separately.

**Timeline to 501(c)(3) approval:** 3–6 months for 1023-EZ; 6–12 months for full 1023. **Workaround:** Use a fiscal sponsor (existing 501(c)(3) sports org) as umbrella while your application is pending. This allows you to accept tax-deductible grants immediately.

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## 2. Program Design

### Age Groups

Organize into three competitive tiers:

- **Mini (Ages 8–10):** Focus on fundamentals, fun, inclusion
- **Junior (Ages 11–13):** Skill development, team dynamics
- **Senior (Ages 14–18):** Competitive play, college exposure, showcase events

### Season Structure

- **Season 1 (Inaugural):** 8-week practice program + 4-game mini season
- **Season 2 onward:** Full 12-week season + playoffs + championship event
- **Off-season:** Camps, clinics, skill-development sessions (year-round engagement)

### Coaching Model

- Head coach: Full-time or high part-time commitment, paid competitively
- Assistant coaches: Part-time, paid hourly or per-session
- All coaches: USA Flag Football certified, background checked, SafeSport certified
- Prioritize: Female coaches at all levels (brand alignment + role model value)
- Coach development pipeline: Partner with local universities (ASU, U of A, GCU) for student coaching apprenticeships

### Player Experience Design

The experience that makes players come back AND tell their friends:

- Every player gets a team jersey (Nike-branded if deal is in place)
- Every player gets a highlight video clip posted at least once per season
- Post-game acknowledgment rituals (not just wins — effort, growth, leadership)
- End-of-season awards: Most Improved, Team MVP, Leader on the Field
- Parent communication: Weekly email update, app notification for schedule changes

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## 3. School District Strategy

School districts are the most scalable player acquisition channel. One MOU with a district can unlock 50–500 potential players via after-school programming.

### Target Districts (Phase 2)

1. **Phoenix Union High School District** — largest in AZ, Title IX-conscious, serves diverse population
2. **Scottsdale Unified School District** — higher income area, strong parent sports involvement, easier to close sponsorship ties
3. **Tempe Union High School District** — strong athletic culture, multiple high schools with existing football programs

### MOU Terms to Offer

- Free program for first season (builds district trust)
- Organization carries all insurance
- Coaches are certified and background-checked
- Organization provides all equipment
- District provides: field/gym access, school-day announcement access, after-school coordinator liaison

### The Title IX Angle

Title IX requires schools to offer substantially equal athletic opportunities for girls and boys. Many AZ school districts are not yet in compliance for football. Positioning as "we help you fulfill your Title IX obligation at zero cost to the district" is a powerful door-opener.

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## 4. Content & Media Strategy

### The Content Philosophy

Nike does not pay for programs. Nike pays for **stories and moments.** Your entire content strategy must be oriented around capturing and publishing compelling girls-in-football stories.

### What to Capture Every Session

- First-person player interviews (30-second phone videos, raw and authentic)
- Game-day highlight clips (edited to 60 seconds for TikTok/Instagram Reels)
- Coach spotlights (especially female coaches)
- Parent reaction videos (genuine emotion = viral potential)
- Before/after skill progression clips (player starts not knowing how to throw; player throws a TD pass 8 weeks later)

### Content Formats by Platform

| Platform | Format | Frequency | Tone |
|---|---|---|---|
| TikTok | 15–60 second raw clips | 5x/week | Authentic, fun, unpolished |
| Instagram | Reels + carousel posts | 4x/week | Polished, brand-forward |
| Instagram Stories | Behind-the-scenes | Daily | Casual, community feel |
| YouTube | 3–5 minute highlight reels | Weekly | Cinematic, emotional |
| Email | Weekly newsletter | Weekly | Informative, community update |
| Facebook | Event announcements | 2x/week | Parent-facing, practical |

### Media Outreach — Local Press

- **Arizona Republic** (azcentral.com) — pitch to sports desk: "Girls flag football league launches in AZ"
- **12News (NBC)** — community sports stories are a regular segment
- **AZFamily / ABC15** — youth sports features
- **Phoenix Business Journal** — if AZ Cardinals partnership secured, this is a business story
- **Target:** 3+ local media mentions before Nike pitch. Each media mention goes in the pitch deck.

### Earned Media Strategy

When pitching local press, lead with:

1. The Title IX angle (policy hook)
2. The NFL/flag football growth story (trend hook)
3. A specific player's story (human hook)
4. The Nike angle — "AZ girls flag football program in talks with Nike" (once true, use it)

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## 5. Grants to Apply For Immediately

These are funded, established grant programs aligned with your mission. Apply immediately — most have annual cycles.

| Grant | Funder | Amount | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| NFL Foundation Youth Football Grant | NFL Foundation | $10,000–$50,000 | Requires USA Flag Football affiliation |
| Women's Sports Foundation Grants | Women's Sports Foundation | $5,000–$25,000 | Multiple grant programs for girls' sports |
| AAUW Community Action Grants | American Association of University Women | $5,000–$10,000 | Girls' STEM + leadership aligned |

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|---|---|---|---|
| Dick's Sporting Goods Foundation | DICK'S Foundation | $5,000–$25,000 | Youth sports, equipment-focused |
| Nike Community Impact Fund | Nike | $10,000–$100,000 | Requires 501(c)(3); apply online |
| Arizona Cardinals Give Back | AZ Cardinals Foundation | $5,000–$20,000 | AZ-based nonprofit sports programs |
| Scotts Miracle-Gro Foundation | Scotts Foundation | $5,000–$15,000 | Youth outdoor sports and activity |
| Captain Planet Foundation | Captain Planet | $2,500–$5,000 | Environmental + youth program |
| AZ Community Foundation | Various AZ donors | $5,000–$50,000 | Broad AZ-based nonprofit grants |

**Grant application volume target:** Apply to at least 6 grants in Year 1. Realistic success rate: 2–3 awards.
**Year 1 grant revenue target:** $30,000–$75,000.

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## 6. Merchandise / Brand Store

### Phase 2 Recommendation: Launch a Simple Merch Line

Merchandise serves two purposes: (1) revenue, and (2) brand awareness through parents and players wearing your gear in public.

**Year 1 Approach:** Print-on-demand via Printful or Printify (no upfront inventory)

- Items: T-shirts, hoodies, hats, water bottles, tote bags
- Fulfillment: Automated via Shopify or Webflow store integration
- Margin: 30–50% on most items
- Investment: $0 upfront (just design time)

**Revenue Potential:** $10,000–$20,000/year once social following reaches 5,000+

**Note:** Once Nike deal is signed, all branded apparel must use Nike gear. Transition merch line to accessories (hats, bags, water bottles) not covered by Nike exclusivity.

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## 7. College Pipeline Program

### Why This Matters for Nike

Flag football is being added at the college level. The NAIA sanctioned women's flag football in 2023. The NCAA is watching. Within 3–5 years, there will be college scholarships for women's flag football.

**Build the pipeline now:**

- Partner with 1–2 college athletic departments (ASU, Grand Canyon University) to create a pathway from your program to college tryouts
- Track any player who advances to college level — these stories are gold for Nike pitch
- Brand positioning: "We created the first girls flag football to college pipeline in AZ"
- Annual "College Showcase Day" event: invite college coaches to watch your Senior division

This differentiates you completely from recreational leagues and makes the Nike national story dramatically stronger.

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## 8. Advisory Board

Recruit a 5-person advisory board. Advisors provide credibility, introductions, and expertise — not day-to-day involvement.

**Recommended advisory board composition:**

1. **Former NFL player or NFL executive** — lends football credibility, potential Nike/NFL connection
2. **Female sports executive** — CEO/CMO from a women's sports organization, Title IX advocate
3. **AZ school district official** — superintendent or athletic director level, accelerates MOU process
4. **Corporate sponsor / marketing executive** — helps build the sponsor pitch, potential introducer to Nike
5. **Youth sports legal expert** — nonprofit law, liability, insurance

**Compensation:** Equity/future stake in the organization (if for-profit), or simply mission alignment (if nonprofit). Advisors at this stage typically serve for mission, not money. Offer board title, mentions in press, and access to the journey.

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## 9. Insurance Requirements

Before any player touches a field, all of the following must be in place:

| Coverage | Type | Purpose |
|---|---|---|
| General Liability | $1M–$2M per occurrence | Protects org from third-party injury claims |
| Participant Accident | Per-player policy | Covers player injuries (medical costs) |
| Directors & Officers | $1M | Protects board from decisions-based claims |
| Coaches Liability | Included in GL or separate | Covers coaching decisions/actions |
| Abuse & Molestation | Separate endorsement | Required by most school districts |

**Provider options:**

- K&K Insurance (youth sports specialist)
- Markel (youth sports policies)
- Via USA Flag Football membership (check included coverage limits)

**Annual cost estimate:** $3,000–$6,000 depending on player count and coverage limits.

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## 10. Technology Stack Recommendations

| Tool | Purpose | Cost |
|---|---|---|
| Webflow | Website (Year 1) | $23–$39/month |
| SportsEngine | Player registration + team management | $99/month (waived or reduced for nonprofits) |

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|---|---|---|
| Mailchimp | Email marketing (up to 500 contacts free) | Free tier → $13/month |
| Canva Pro | Social media content design | $13/month |
| Google Workspace | Email, Docs, Sheets, Drive | $6/user/month |
| QuickBooks (Simple Start) | Nonprofit accounting | $30/month |
| Stripe | Donation and payment processing | 2.9% + $0.30 per transaction |
| Later or Buffer | Social media scheduling | $18/month |
| Zoom | Board meetings, coach training | $16/month |

**Year 1 Technology Total:** ~$300–$400/month ($3,600–$4,800/year)

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## Summary — The 10 Things That Will Make This Work

1. **501(c)(3) status:** Do not skip this. It unlocks grants, Nike, and school districts.
2. **Female coaches front and center:** This is the brand. Girls need to see themselves as the leaders.
3. **School districts first:** They are the distribution channel. Three districts = hundreds of potential players.
4. **Content from Day 1:** The highlight reel you will show Nike in September 2026 is being filmed starting in July.
5. **NFL Flag affiliation:** The warm path to Nike runs through this channel.
6. **AZ Cardinals relationship:** A letter on Cardinals letterhead changes every conversation you have.
7. **Apply for 6 grants immediately:** Year 1 is grant-funded while sponsors are being built.
8. **Build the advisory board before you need it:** Advisors open the doors that would otherwise be closed.
9. **Be patient with Nike:** The worst thing you can do is pitch Nike before you have traction. Build it first.
10. **Build the national story into every conversation:** You are not building an AZ program. You are building the national platform for girls flag football and AZ is the proof of concept.

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